

Llamapalooza comforts college students during final exams

By Matthew Cantor, The Guardian, adapted by Newsela staff on 05.10.19

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Lorenzo the llama, known to friends as Zoe, at University of California, Berkeley. Photo by: Matthew Cantor/The Guardian

This month, many college students are dealing with final exams. It's a stressful time.

So, to fight the tense atmosphere, one of the country's top schools has been bringing in llamas to school. Yes, llamas — those lovable furry creatures often found at petting zoos.

On May 3, students flocked to the Memorial Glade at the University of California, Berkeley, for Llamapalooza. It's a human-llama social occasion on a sunny lawn. The eight animals were scattered throughout the crowd. They were munching grass. Meanwhile, their adoring fans petted, fed and photographed them.

The event happens twice every school year. It's intended to help Berkeley students relax before the tests. For many, it works.

Grace Park, a junior, had an exam that very day — but her interactions with the animals left her feeling "significantly less stressed," she said. "It's very wholesome," added Mazel Mihardja, also a junior.

Ana Claire Mancia, who studies business at Berkeley, launched Llamapalooza a year and a half ago. She graduates this year.

Calm And At Peace

"When you're around a llama, you become very calm and at peace," she said. Some people may think of the animals as spitters. This is unfair, she noted. Such behavior is just for disputes between llamas. When it comes to humans, "you would have to be super in its face and irritate it for a llama to spit at you."

Indeed, despite being surrounded by overexcited humans, the llamas themselves remained remarkably calm. Their drooping eyelashes made them seem relaxed as they munched on the school's grass.

Many students took pre-exam comfort in the llamas' fur, praised as "quite fuzzy" and "surprisingly soft." "I want to pet them forever," said Phoebe Kay, a junior from Australia.

However, interactions weren't limited to petting. Mancia taught The Guardian what is known as a "llama greeting." The trick is to approach the animal nose-to-nose and "breathe the same air," she said.

Having heard that llamas could be moody, I was initially nervous about engaging closely with the animals. However, such fears were unnecessary. I was debating how close to get, when a llama named Munay performed the greeting uninvited, blowing hot llama air from his nostrils. It was as soothing as advertised.

Feeding From Mouth To Mouth

That success inspired us to go further and feed the oldest creature of the bunch. He's a 14-year-old male called Quinoa for his speckled head. The process was unnerving. The feeder must provide the carrot directly from their own mouth. However, Quinoa quickly plucked it from my teeth and it disappeared in an instant.

This easygoing relationship is why George Caldwell believes they are so well-suited to such visits. He raises the llamas and brings them to schools.

Thanks to a long history living among humans in South America, "these guys developed social skills that are just amazing," Caldwell says. "That's the way they can put up with all these people coming around them and touching them and everything, because they realize their intentions are just social, family: good intentions."

Caldwell's dream, he said, would be to enable more human-llama hangouts. Not only would it relieve stress, but it would also ensure that humans don't abandon the animals. "The llamas, if they're gonna be around in the 21st, 22nd century, they need to get jobs," he said.

Caldwell had been bringing the animals to Berkeley to lower the stress of the students for several years before Mancia launched Llamapalooza. Still, the event was somewhat unknown.

Llamapalooza changed that. Now, as many as 2,000 students may have showed up, Mancia says.

The llamas' success has inspired many local universities to follow Berkeley's lead. Quinoa and the gang have made new fans at the University of California, San Francisco, and the University of

California, Davis. They also visited Stanford University. Earlier in May, they offered comfort at a high school where a student had recently passed away.

"These llamas allow you to love them. And once you get a big dose of love, that changes whatever mood you're in," Caldwell said. "That's the magic of the llamas."